

BURNOUT

Burnout looks similar to stress, depression, or anxiety. Because of this overlap, people may not realize burnout is the real issue.

Burnout symptoms can be recognised physically, emotionally, and behaviourally.

People with burnout may become:

- Less productive
- Frequently absent from work
- Excessively tired
- Irritable

In some cases:

- People may rely on excessive alcohol or drugs
- Eating habits may change

How Burnout Can Be Misinterpreted

Because symptoms overlap, burnout is often misunderstood:

- Constant exhaustion - blamed on stress
- Lack of motivation - mistaken for laziness or depression
- Irritability - seen as anxiety or mood swings
- Detachment from work - seen as boredom, not burnout

Burnout vs Depression – Symptoms Comparison

Aspect	Burnout Symptoms	Depression Symptoms
Emotional state	Feeling emotionally exhausted and drained	Persistent sadness, emptiness, or hopelessness
Motivation	Loss of motivation specifically related to work	Loss of interest in most or all activities
Attitude	Cynicism, detachment, negativity toward work	Feelings of worthlessness or excessive guilt
Cognitive function	Trouble thinking, poor decision-making	Difficulty concentrating, slowed thinking
Empathy	Reduced empathy and emotional numbness	Emotional withdrawal and loss of pleasure
Social behaviour	Social withdrawal, irritability, restlessness	Social withdrawal, isolation
Physical symptoms	Headaches, back pain, body aches	Fatigue, low energy, physical slowing
Sleep	Insomnia, anxiety-related sleep problems	Insomnia or excessive sleeping
Severity	Usually improves with rest or time away from work	Persists regardless of rest
Risk level	Serious but situational	Can be life-threatening if untreated

Burnout vs Depression – Causes Comparison

Aspect	Causes of Burnout	Causes of Depression
Origin	Primarily environmental and work-related	Biological, psychological, and social factors
Workload	Long hours, excessive workload	May occur even without work stress
Expectations	Unrealistic goals, perfectionism	High self-criticism, low self-worth
Environment	Toxic workplace culture, low compensation	Social isolation, lack of support
Life balance	Poor work-life balance, caregiving burden	Major life changes, losses, trauma
Biology	Not primarily biological	Genetics, brain chemistry imbalance
Stress	Chronic job-related stress	Long-term stress or sudden emotional shocks
Reversibility	Often improves by changing environment	Requires clinical treatment (therapy/medication)

Burnout has a clear external cause (usually work-related) and is situation-specific, while depression is a clinical condition that can occur without obvious triggers and affects all areas of life. Burnout typically improves with rest.

Example – Burnout (Riya):

Riya felt exhausted, irritated, and disconnected from her job. Every morning felt heavy, but when she took a

long vacation and stepped away from work, she slowly felt like herself again. Her problem came from work pressure, and rest helped her recover — this was burnout.

Example – Depression (Aman):

Aman felt empty all the time. Even on weekends or holidays, nothing felt enjoyable. He was tired, sad, and hopeless without knowing why. Rest didn't help. He needed support from a mental health professional — this was depression.

How Psychologists Differentiate Burnout from Other Conditions

Psychologists compare multiple assessments.

Tests Used

- BAT - work-related exhaustion, detachment, thinking problems
- Depression tests (PHQ-9, Beck) - sadness, hopelessness, loss of interest
- Anxiety tests (GAD-7) - fear, worry, physical tension
- Clinical interview - questions about life, work, sleep, and mood

Interpretation (Example)

- High BAT score + low depression score - Burnout
- High depression score across life areas - Depression

SOME TOOLS USED

Burnout Assessment Tool (BAT)

BAT is a self-report questionnaire. A person answers statements about how they have been feeling at work over a recent period.

Responses are usually on a scale:

- Never
- Rarely
- Sometimes
- Often
- Always

Scoring Method

- Each response is given a numerical value (e.g., 1–5)
- Scores are averaged for each of the four categories
- The four scores are combined to produce one overall burnout score

Burnout Classification

- Low burnout
- Moderate burnout risk
- High burnout

Core Burnout Symptoms Measured by BAT

BAT measures four categories, not just tiredness:

1. Exhaustion

- Feeling mentally and physically drained
- Example: “I feel exhausted at the end of my workday”

2. Mental Distance

- Feeling detached, cynical, or emotionally distant from work
- Example: “I feel indifferent about my job”

3. Cognitive Impairment

- Trouble thinking, concentrating, remembering
- Example: “I find it hard to focus at work”

4. Emotional Impairment

- Difficulty managing emotions
- Example: “I feel overwhelmed by my emotions at work”

Maslach Burnout Inventory (MBI)

The Maslach Burnout Inventory (MBI) is considered the gold standard for measuring burnout. It has been widely used since 1981 to study burnout in professionals such as doctors, nurses, teachers, and other workers. The MBI measures three separate dimensions of burnout.

These are assessed independently and are not combined into one total score.

The MBI asks people how often they feel:

- exhausted at work,
- emotionally distant from work,
- or ineffective in their job.

Their answers are grouped into three scores that help understand how burnout shows up, rather than diagnosing a mental illness.

1. Emotional Exhaustion (EE)

- Feeling emotionally and physically drained
- Feeling worn out and unable to face another workday

2. Depersonalization (DP) / Cynicism

- Feeling detached, distant, or negative toward people at work
- Reduced emotional connection to clients, patients, or colleagues

3. Reduced Personal Accomplishment (PA)

- Feeling ineffective or unproductive
- Feeling that work lacks meaning or impact

How the Test Works

- The MBI is a self-report questionnaire.
- It contains statements about work-related feelings.
- For each statement, the person selects how often it applies to them using a 0–6 scale: Never to Every Day

Questions:	Never	A Few Times per Year	Once a Month	A Few Times per Month	Once a Week	A Few Times per Week	Every Day
Section A:	0	1	2	3	4	5	6
I feel emotionally drained by my work.							
Working with people all day long requires a great deal of effort.							
I feel like my work is breaking me down.							
I feel frustrated by my work.							
I feel I work too hard at my job.							
It stresses me too much to work in direct contact with people.							
I feel like I'm at the end of my tether.							
Total score – SECTION A							

https://annualsession.michigandental.org/wp-content/uploads/Daniels_Burnout-Prevention-Strategies.pdf (for questions of other section)

Scoring Method

- Each question belongs to one of the three dimensions (EE, DP, or PA).
- Scores are calculated by:
 - Adding up the responses for questions within each dimension.
- This results in three separate scores:
 - Emotional Exhaustion score
 - Depersonalization score
 - Personal Accomplishment score

How Burnout Is Interpreted

- High Emotional Exhaustion (EE) - Higher burnout risk
- High Depersonalization (DP) - Increased cynicism and detachment
- Low Personal Accomplishment (PA) - Feelings of inefficiency and low achievement

Burnout is identified by patterns across these three scores, not by one number.

Other example: Depression-Like Pattern (Not Pure Burnout)

- EE: High
- DP: Low
- PA: Low

What this means:

The person feels tired and ineffective, but not cynical or detached from work.

Interpretation:

This pattern raises concern for depression, especially if symptoms exist outside work, would use depression tests (PHQ-9, Beck) to confirm.

How Professionals Use the MBI

- Researchers: To study burnout trends in different professions
- Organizations: To identify workplace burnout patterns
- Clinicians: As a screening tool alongside other assessments

The MBI can measure burnout-related feelings, but it cannot diagnose a mental illness like depression or anxiety by itself.

Copenhagen Burnout Inventory (CBI)

The Copenhagen Burnout Inventory is a questionnaire used to measure burnout, mainly focusing on exhaustion and fatigue. Shows where burnout comes from. Helps distinguish work burnout vs general exhaustion

CBI asks how tired and exhausted you feel and helps identify whether burnout comes from work, life in general, or dealing with people.

CBI measures burnout in three areas:

1. Personal Burnout

- General physical and emotional exhaustion
- Not limited to work

Example:

“I feel tired all the time”

2. Work-Related Burnout

- Exhaustion caused specifically by work

Example:

“My work drains my energy”

3. Client-Related Burnout

- Burnout linked to working with people (clients, patients, students)

Example:

“Working with people is emotionally exhausting”

How the Test Works

- CBI is a self-report questionnaire
- Questions ask how often or to what degree you feel exhausted

Common response options:

- Always
- Often
- Sometimes
- Seldom
- Never / Almost never

Scoring Method

- Each question is scored (for example):
 - Always = 100
 - Often = 75
 - Sometimes = 50
 - Seldom = 25
 - Never = 0
- Scores for questions in each section are averaged

You get three separate scores:

- Personal burnout score
- Work-related burnout score
- Client-related burnout score

They are not combined into one number.

How Burnout Is Interpreted(for each category)

- 0–49 → Low burnout
- 50–74 → Moderate burnout
- 75–100 → High burnout

Examples

- High work-related burnout, but low personal burnout → problem is mainly work
- High personal burnout → exhaustion affects life overall
- High client-related burnout → emotional strain from people-facing work

HOW MODEL CAN PREDICT

By recognizing patterns in what the user says, how they say it, and where the problem seems to come from. Model looks if, is the distress mainly work-related or a specific role/task (burnout)? or global and exists across life (depression/anxiety)?

The model analyses emotional tone and language :

- Words : exhausted, drained, hopeless, anxious
- Sentence patterns : whether the sentence is pointing out to particular situation or general life
- Repetition : How the particular word or phrase is repeated
- Emotional intensity

Burnout language:

- tired, drained, work, deadlines, pressure

Depression language:

- empty, worthless, pointless, hopeless

Anxiety language:

- worried, scared, tense, overthinking

People use similar words for different problems

- “I’m tired” - could be burnout or depression
- “I’m stressed” - could be burnout or anxiety

So the model must not rely on one word alone.

How a model avoids confusion

Look at the pattern, not a single sentence

The model listens over time, not just once.

- Burnout - tired mostly when talking about work
- Depression - tired all the time, even outside work
- Anxiety - tired because of constant worry or fear

Context + repetition matters more than keywords

Check where the problem comes from

The model asks gentle follow-up questions:

- “Does this feeling get better when you’re away from work?”
- “Do you still enjoy things outside work?”
- “Are you worried about specific things, or is it a constant feeling?”

Answer Interpretation:

- Better with rest - burnout
- No relief anywhere - depression
- Driven by worry/fear – anxiety

The model separates symptoms:

- Low energy, work-related - Burnout
- Low mood, hopelessness - Depression
- Fear, worry, tension - Anxiety

Even if symptoms overlap, the situation and conditions can help differentiate.

The model never decides based on one thing.

It combines: (Example)

- Emotional words
- Topic (work / life / future)
- Duration (weeks vs months)
- Improvement with rest
- Loss of pleasure
- Worry intensity

Allow “mixed states” instead of forcing labels

Instead of saying “This is depression”, the model can say:

- “Strong burnout signals”
- “Burnout with anxiety features”
- “Possible depression risk, consider professional help”

This helps reduce mistakes.